

CHAPTER 24

MEENA WAITS FOR ME

'Never again call me to an exhibition of wine.'

As the car turned to West Fort, my neighbourhood where old buildings of the Travancore royalty's remnants stood their ground amidst mushrooming modern architecture, my thoughts were on my wife. Shankar, during his visits to the jail, had been giving me tidbits of information about her—that she was mostly silent and barely eating. She was a typical homemaker, the mother of my children, with virtually no social life.

She seldom complained about my long hours at work. She once laughed when someone, during a water shortage at home, commented that I was so obsessed with liquid propulsion in ISRO's rockets that I have forgotten about the faulty water tank that fed our modest kitchen at home.

She stood by me through the travails and tantrums that work pressure brought upon me.

Meenakshi Ammal, my wife, was born as the second of the thirteen children of her parents. Her father, Ramaswamy, did coir business and had properties at Chalai in Trivandrum, where my family also owned land. The families were related, and when the proposal came sometime in 1967, I went to meet her. I liked her simplicity and readily agreed for the marriage.

The previous year was one of high and low for me, with my joining TERLS in September 1966 and my mother dying in November. Meena and I got married at a simple ceremony on 8 September 1967, attended by my extended family and a few colleagues that included APJ Abdul Kalam.